had been killed, though many men were hit by shrapnel and were walking wounded.

Around the time the final Chinese attack on Alpha Company fizzled out at around 4 p.m., Chinese artillery fire cut the communication line with Brigade HQ. As attempts were being made to raise Battalion HQ on the wireless, GOC 4 Division took a baffling decision, ordering Hoshiar to withdraw 4 Garhwal. Even though the accepted tactics of the Indian Army at the time suggested that covering troops, after having achieved their objective of delaying the enemy should fall back, it was not a rule written in stone. Now Nuranang was proving to be an ideal defensive position, which by virtue of being boxed in by steep cliffs on either side could not be outflanked. Commander 62 Brigade should have realized that he could now use the hours of darkness to replenish and reinforce this position. Instead, in a repeat of 1 Sikh's fight at Bum-la, Lieutenant Colonel B. M. Bhattacharjea was asked to break contact and withdraw to Se-la at night. They were told 1 Sikh would serve the men a hot meal on arrival at Se-la Top.

Unfortunately, shortly after the first reports of the Chinese attacks started coming in, 4 Division had set a poor example by pulling out two Dogra companies from Senge for its own protection. For all the talk of holding Se-la, after having taken up defensive positions, there was obviously no actual tactical plan in place and the order to 4 Garhwal to withdraw reflects this major shortcoming in the plans of 4 Division. In combat situations, it is extremely hard to speculate on the ifs and buts of any scenario. Yet, the orders to abandon the defences and pull out made no sense whatsoever. Instead of building on the day's success and forcing the Chinese to reinforce failure, the brigade commander threw it away and virtually signed his own and the brigade's death warrant. Until that morning, 4 Sikh LI was deployed around the Two Lakes area between the Garhwalis at Nuranang and the two battalions at Se-la Top. The orders to abandon this position and pull back into a tight square on Se-la Top were a complete reversal of the earlier plan. Had this decision not been taken, 4 Sikh LI could and should have been used as a reserve for 4 Garhwal. As it ultimately panned out, even the other companies of 4 Garhwal had not come into play by last light on 17 November.

From the sublime to the ridiculous! How else can one describe the events that were to unfold in the next few hours as the much-vaunted Se-la